

In what follows, I'll set preference hedonism to the side, and focus on the success theory. Most of the issues that will come up would also apply to preference hedonism — so if you prefer that view, you can substitute accordingly.

Here's a problem for the view that desires play the central role which
the success theory gives to them:

Would it make your life go better to be injected with the addictive
drug?

Intuitively, no. You will always have to remember to have ample supplies of the drug around, and will have to give yourself an injection every morning. None of these are things that you want to do.

This is of course a made up case. But there are real life cases which are
relevantly like it.

But even after we introduce this distinction between summative and global theories, one might think that a problem somewhat like the one posed by the case of Violet remains. This is brought out by the example of the grass-counter:

Here the desire to spend his life counting blades of grass is a global desire. So even the global success theory has to say that the man has a better life counting blades of grass than he would have achieving great and useful things in mathematics.

One can have two different kinds of reactions to this case.

One way to bring out the second response is to imagine that the grass-counter is someone you love — perhaps a child. Suppose that you want them to have the best life possible, and that you know that they desire life as a grass-counter. Wouldn't you still hope that they moved on from grass-counting at some point?

If you think this, then this would be a reason to abandon the success
theory in favor of what Parfit calls an **objective list theory**.

The natural question for the objective list theorist is: what determines
what gets on the objective list?

There are different answers to this question. The one we will explore goes back to Aristotle.

Let's forget about human lives for a second, and think about the lives of
non-human animals. Consider the following two beasts:

We can ask, of either animal, what it would take for their life to go best.

Do we get the same answer in the two cases?

When we ask this question, a number of plausible answers suggest themselves:

Humans have bodies (of certain distinctive kinds).

Humans are social animals, who live with other humans.

Indeed, these unanswered questions are the source of the one of the central objections to virtue theory, which is that the theory does not seem to tell us as much as we would want a moral theory to tell us.

Consider the trolley problem. What does the virtue ethicist tell us to do in each version of the case? It is a little hard to say.

Humans have bodies (of certain distinctive kinds).

Humans are social animals,
who live with other humans.

There are really two related problems here. The first is that virtue ethics does not issue the kind of clear guidance in genuine moral dilemmas that consequentialism and deontological theories seem to give us. If you are attracted to virtue ethics, you should try to think about a difficult moral decision, and see how thinking about the good human life and the virtues it involves might help.

The second is a worry that virtue theory will not give us the resources to see where our own moral intuitions go wrong. If our starting point is our view of the best human life, could virtue ethics ever show us that our assumptions about morality are fundamentally flawed?

In what follows, I'll set preference head on this to the side, and focus on

substitute accordingly.

apply to preference hedonism — so if you prefer that view, you can

the success theory. Most of the issues that will come up would also

the success theory gives to them:

Here's a problem for the view that desires play the central role which

Would it make your life go better to be injected with the addictive

drug?

of the drug around, and will have to give yourself an injection every

morning. None of these are things that you want to do.

Intuitively, no. You will always have to remember to have ample supplies

This is of course a made up case. But there are real life cases which are

relevantly like it.

But even after we introduce this distinctive and

global theories, one might think that a problem with what like the one

posed by the case of Violet remains. This is brought out by the example

of the grass-counter:

better hunting blades of grass than he would have achieving great

desire. So even though the global success theory has to say that the man has a

and useful things in mathematics.

Here the desire to spend his life counting blades of grass is a global

grass-counting at some point?

One way to bring out the second response is to imagine that the grass-

counter is someone you love — perhaps a child. Suppose that you want

life as a grass-counter. Wouldn't you still hope that they moved on from

them to have the best life possible, and that you know that they desire

if you think this, then this would be a reason to abandon the success

theory in favor of what Parfit calls an objective list theory.

The natural question for the objective list theorist is: what determines

what gets on the objective list?

There are different answers to this question. The one we will explore

goes back to Aristotle.

non-human animals. Consider the following two beasts:



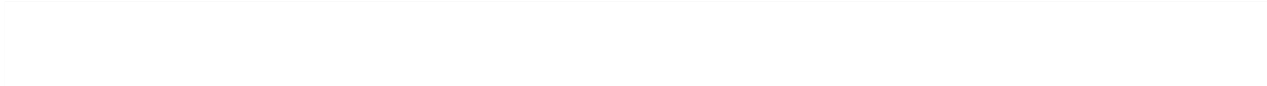
Let's forget about human lives for a second, and think about the lives of

We can ask, of either animal, what it would take for their life to go best.

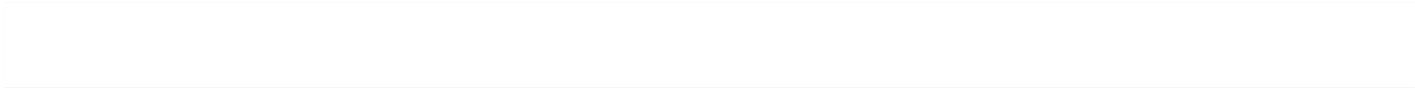
Do we get the same answer in the two cases?

When we ask this question, a number of plausible answers suggest

then send | vves:



Humans have bodies (of certain kinds).



Humans are social animals, who live with other humans.

Indeed, these unanswered questions are the source of the central

objections to virtue theory, which is that the theory does not seem to tell us

much as we would want a moral theory to tell us.

Consider the trolley problem. What does the virt ethicist tell us to do in each

version of the case? It is a little hard to say.

There are really two related problems here. The first is that virtues do

not is the kind of guidance in genuine moral dilemmas that



decision, and see how thinking about the good human life and the virtues it

involves might help.

consequentialism and deontological theories to give us a

attracted to virtues, you should try to think about difficult moral

The second is a worry that virtue theory will not give us the resources to see

the best human life, could virtuous that our assumption

about morality are fundamentally flawed?

where our moral intuition is wrong. If our starting point is our view of